

**Committee:** General Assembly 3

**Topic:** Protecting the Rights and Cultural Heritage of Climate-Displaced Populations

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## Introduction

Millions are displaced annually by climate change related issues, including rising sea levels, droughts, storms, and extreme weather. According to the Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre (IDMC), disasters displace millions of people annually, and predict that hundreds of millions could become climate migrants in the coming years. However, there is no formal international recognition for “climate refugees,” leaving displaced populations vulnerable to statelessness and human rights abuses. Forced relocations strip away the generational ties to ancestral lands, risking permanent loss of indigenous culture, such as languages, traditions, and sacred heritage.

With the rising number of “climate refugees,” there is an urgent need for international legal frameworks, inclusive governance, and active preservation of cultural heritage.

## Key Words

*Climate Displacement* - forced or involuntary movement of people within or across borders due to sudden or progressive climate change or disasters

*Climate Refugee* - non-legal term for a person displaced from their home due to climate change or disasters

*Cultural Heritage* - anything (tangible and intangible) passed down from past generations that carry historical and cultural importance

*Statelessness* - condition of not having citizenship or nationality under any country by law

*Internal Displacement* - forced movement of people within the borders of the country they live in, due to violence, persecution, or other conflicts

*Loss and Damage* - unavoidable and irreversible negative impacts of climate change that occur despite mitigation and/or adaptation efforts and methods

*Free, Prior, and Informed Consent (FPIC)* - specific human right process that allows Indigenous Peoples the right to give or withhold consent to any activity may affect their lands, resources, and lifestyle

## General Overview

Climate change has altered geographical habitability in many places across the globe, most notably in tropical regions, low-lying coastal regions, and parts of the Middle East. According to the study published by the journal Nature Geoscience, it states that if governments fail to curb global temperature rise to 1.5°C above the pre-industrial era, areas in the tropic band that stretches either side of the equator risk changing into a new environment that will “hit the limit of human adaptation. (Earth.Org) As for the Middle East, a number of areas in Gulf Cooperation Council countries will be affected by extreme heat waves and elevated wet-bulb temperatures by the end of the 21st century. This could lead to chaos and extensive socioeconomic loss caused by climate change-related disasters in the rapidly expanding urban areas of the Middle East due to the vulnerability of critical urban infrastructure and systems. (Salimi, Al-Ghamdi) This drives an unprecedented surge in internal and cross border displacement driven by both sudden-onset disasters—floods, hurricanes—and slow-onset crisis—droughts and sea-level rise.

Displaced communities frequently experience regulatory grey areas. Because international refugee laws do not formally define “climate refugees,” affected individuals miss out on institutional protections, resettlement rights, and official asylum channels. International migration following short term disasters is only occasionally protected under humanitarian visas though such protections are often provisional and not legally binding. Likewise, international mitigation following long-term disasters is not covered unless the provision of support by the local government is denied on the basis of race, religion, membership of a particular social group, or political opinion. (Elsadig Elsheikh) Even for those people who are in agreement that climate-induced displaced persons are in dire need of protection, their reasons vary on their disagreement: climate migration is mainly internal; isolation environment/climate reasons is difficult; opening the 1951 Refugee Convention may be politically unfeasible and it weakens existing refugee status; and other humanitarian avenues may be available. (Hosseini Ayazi)

## Major Parties Involved

*Local governments* - control immigration policies

*Climate refugees* - people directly affected by climate change and environmental disasters

*Indigenous communities* - at risk due to loss of cultural heritage from climate change and disasters

*United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR)*

*International Organizations for Migration (IOM)*

*United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC)*

*Warsaw International Mechanism for Loss and Damage (WIM)*

## Timeline of Relevant Events

| Year | Event                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1951 | The Refugee Convention was adopted to establish the definition of refugees and set out basic rights and protection frameworks for them.                                                                            |
| 1992 | United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) established the foundation for international cooperation on climate change and relevant mitigation strategies.                                      |
| 2005 | Hurricane Katrina in the United States displaced hundreds of thousands of people, highlighting the urgent need for governments and organizations to prepare for the consequences of large-scale natural disasters. |
| 2010 | During the COP16 climate conference in Cancun, Mexico, governments formally recognized climate displacement as an issue to be addressed for the first time.                                                        |
| 2013 | The Warsaw International Mechanism for Loss and Damage was established to address loss and damage due to climate change.                                                                                           |

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|------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2015 | The Paris Agreement was established under the UNFCCC to strengthen international cooperation in mitigating global climate change and adaptation methods.                                      |
| 2015 | The Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction was established to shift priorities from reacting to global disasters to preventing and reducing risks of disasters.                         |
| 2018 | The Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration and Global Compact on Refugees was adopted, recognizing climate change and disasters as key drivers of migration and displacement. |
| 2022 | The Loss and Damage Fund was established at COP27 in Sharm el-Sheikh to provide financial support to vulnerable countries.                                                                    |
| 2023 | UNESCO Policy Document on Climate Action for World Heritage was adopted to direct attention to the effects of climate change on cultural heritages.                                           |
| 2024 | UNFCCC Technical Work on Cultural Heritage and Climate Displacement established to directly address non-economic losses such as tradition, cultural heritage, and displacement                |

## Relevant Documents

### [1951 Refugee Convention](#)

*Defines who a refugee is and establishes legal obligations to protect them*

### [United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change](#)

*Adopted in 1992 to limit human impacts on climate*

### [Warsaw International Mechanism for Loss and Damage](#)

*Established under UNFCCC to address loss and damage caused by climate related disasters in vulnerable countries*

### [2015 Paris Agreement](#)

*International treaty on climate change, providing framework for climate action and support for vulnerable states*

### [The Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction](#)

*Provides countries with action plan to reduce disaster risks and strengthen economic resilience*

### [Global Compact for Safe, Orderly, and Regular Migration \(GCM\)](#)

*Provides mitigation measures relevant to disasters and climate change*

### [UNESCO Policy Document on Climate Action for World Heritage](#)

*Provides guidelines to protect cultural heritages from climate and environmental threats*

## UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP)

*International agreement on the rights of Indigenous peoples worldwide*

### Possible Solutions

1. Develop an international system that collects, monitors, and analyzes data on sea-level rise, drought and weather patterns, and other climate or environment related trends across countries and states to assess risks for climate displacement. This would allow governments and organizations to respond to and help people before they are displaced.
2. Establish programs to protect the cultural rights of climate displaced populations and refugees after they arrive in new communities. This may include integrating the culture of the displaced community into schools to preserve culture and prevent permanent loss of culture due to displacement.
3. Allow communities directly affected by climate change and disasters to participate and have a major say in the programs designed to relocate refugees. Ensuring participation of affected groups would allow the programs to not only bring refugees to new homes, but to preserve traditional and cultural lifestyles, identities, and other heritages.
4. Establish clear international legal protections that guarantee housing, healthcare, education, legal documentation, employment, and other access to basic human rights to prevent marginalization and exclusion of immigrants.

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